This book belongs to

Merry Christmas!

Juniper

and the Little Lost Star

A Cozy Christmas Eve Adventure

Clara Winterbourne

Juniper and the Little Lost Star
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For everyone who has ever waited
a long, long time
for something wonderful.

Juniper the hedgehog had never, ever seen Christmas.

Every year, when the first frost came, her eyes grew heavy. She curled into a prickly ball in her cozy burrow under the old holly tree... and she slept right through it.

Every spring, Juniper asked the same question.

“Grandma, what is Christmas like?”

“Oh, it sparkles,” said Grandma. “The windows glow like little suns. And high above Hollyberry Village shines one special star, to show Santa the way.”

“One day,” Juniper whispered, “I'll see it.”

This winter, Grandma knitted her a scarf, red as holly berries, with two white stripes.

“For the Christmas you'll finally see,” she said, and tucked her in.

Juniper yawned the biggest yawn. Her eyes went close... close... closed.

Then, on the darkest night of the whole year...
THUMP!
Something bumped against the burrow door. Something small.
Something bright.

Juniper opened one eye. Then the other.

Golden light was peeking through the door. She tiptoed outside, into her very first snow. It was soft and sparkly, and much, much colder than she had ever imagined.

"Ooh! Cold, cold, COLD!" she squeaked, hopping from foot to foot.

“Hello?” Juniper called softly.

There, in a little dip in the snow, sat a tiny star.

It had a sweet round face, and it was sniffling.

“Oh no, oh no,” said the star. “I fell down, and I can't get back up!”

“I'm Glimmer,” said the star. “I'm Hollyberry's star. Tonight is Christmas Eve, and if I'm not back in the sky by midnight, Santa won't find the village!”

Glimmer's light flickered... and dimmed... just a little.

“What can I do?” Juniper wondered. “I'm only small.”

Juniper's tummy did a flip. No Santa? No sparkle? Not on the one Christmas she was finally awake for!

She held up her paws.

“Little light, little light, don't you fade tonight,” she said. “I'll help you home.”

But how do you carry a star? Glimmer was too warm for paws.

“Hop on my prickles!” said Juniper.

Glimmer settled between her spines, snug as a button.

“Hee hee!” giggled Glimmer. “You're like a pincushion!”

Off they went, crunch, crunch, crunch, through the snow.

First, Juniper tried the holly tree. She climbed up, up, up… all the way to the third branch.

Then she looked down. “Oh my,” she said, and climbed back down, very carefully.

The sky was still far, far away.

“Need a lift?” chirped Ruby the robin.

She grabbed Juniper's scarf and flapped with all her might. Flap, flap, FLAP! Juniper rose one.:. two... three inches...

...and PLOP! Into a snowdrift.

“Perhaps,” puffed Ruby, “you're a little too prickly for flying.”

Out from behind a pine tree trotted a fox with a tail like a torch.

"I'm Ember," he said. "The highest place I know is the top of Hollyberry Hill. Hold on!"

Juniper held on tight, and away they bounded, whoosh, whoosh, whoosh, over the moonlit snow.

From the top of the hill, they could see the whole village below. But the sky was still far, far away.

Ember's ears drooped. Juniper's heart felt heavy, too. And Glimmer was growing paler.

“I'm so cold,” she whispered. “And so far from home.”

Juniper didn't think twice. She unwound her brand-new scarf and wrapped it around Glimmer, gently, gently. The wind nipped at Juniper's neck, but she didn't mind one bit.

“There,” said Juniper. “Now you're not cold. And you're not alone.”

Glimmer's light flickered warmer.

“Whooo is out so late?” A great grey owl landed on a branch. It was Old Oakley, the wisest bird in the wood.

Juniper told him everything, all in one big breath. Oakley blinked his big moon eyes. “Stars don't rise by climbing or flying,” he said. “Stars rise on light. And Glimmer needs more light than she has left.”

Juniper looked down at Hollyberry Village. Every window was dark. Everyone was fast asleep.

“Then we'll wake up the light!” she said.

She left Glimmer safe with Oakley and tumbled down the hill, roly-poly, roly-poly, all the way to the village.

Tap, tap, tap! Ruby pecked at the windows. Ember yipped at the doors. At first, nothing happened.

So Juniper, tiny Juniper, stood in the snow and sang as loud as she could:

“Little light, little light, won't you shine tonight?”

One window glowed. Then another. Then the bakery, and the school, and the little blue house at the end of the lane.

A little girl held up a candle. A grandpa switched on the tree lights. A baby's night-light blinked on.

Soon every window in Hollyberry Village was glowing like a little sun.

Up on the hill, Glimmer began to shine. Brighter... brighter... BRIGHTER!

Then, slowly, gently, she began to float, up past Oakley's branch, up past the tallest pine, up, up, up into the night, with the red scarf trailing behind her like a ribbon.

The village clock began to chime. Bong... bong... bong...

Twelve!

Juniper held her breath. And across the big round moon flew a sleigh pulled by reindeer, following one bright little star straight to Hollyberry Village.

All across the village, everyone cheered.

Snow. Sparkle. Windows like little suns. One special star.

“So this is Christmas,” Juniper whispered, smiling so wide that her cheeks glowed.

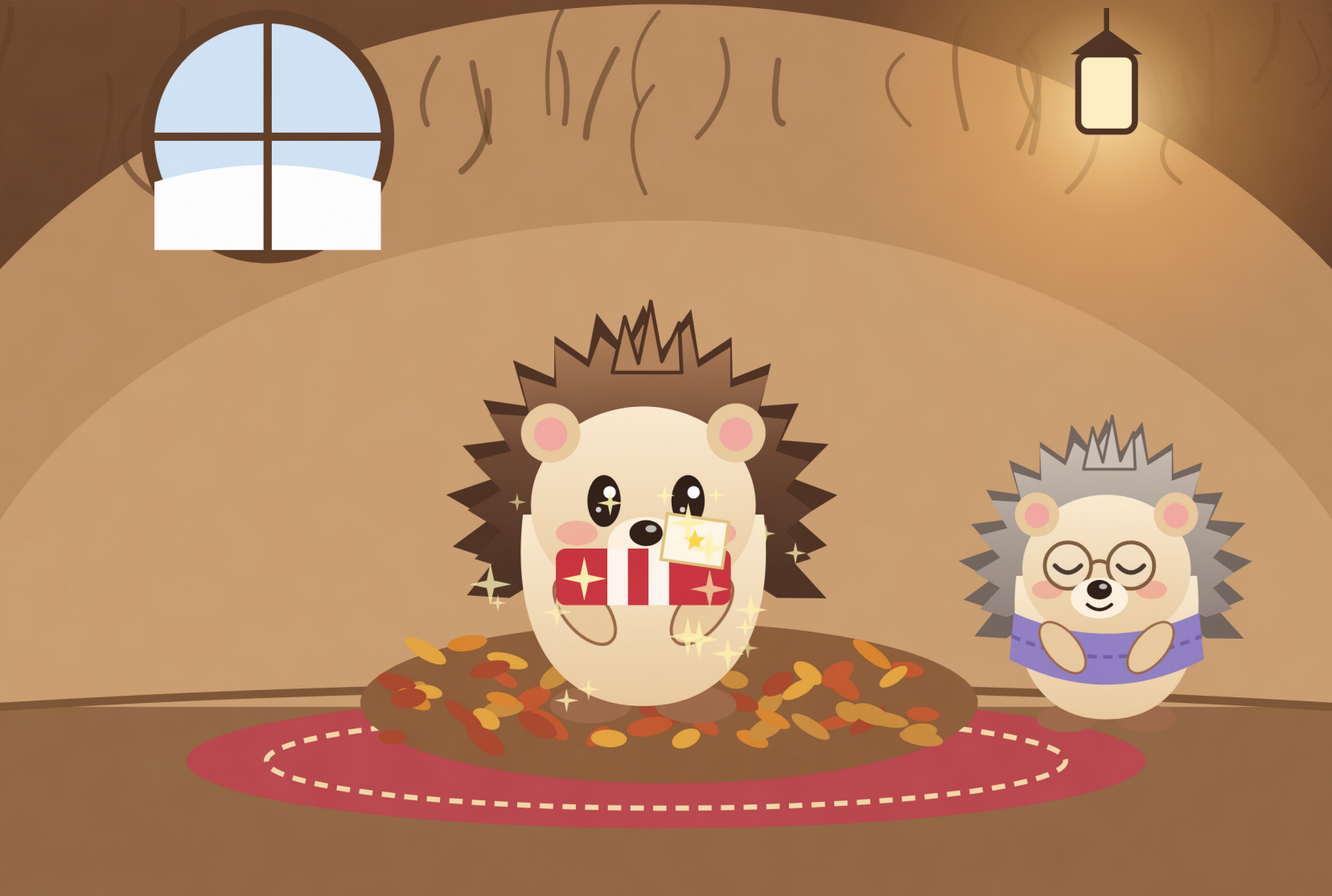
Ember curled his warm tail around her. Ruby snuggled close. And they watched until her eyes grew heavy once more.

In the morning, Juniper woke in her own snug bed. Had it all been a dream?

Then she saw it: her red scarf, folded by her pillow and dusted with stardust. Tucked inside was a tiny note:

Thank you for lighting my way home. Look up! — G.

Grandma smiled a knowing smile.



That night, Juniper peeked out of her burrow one last time.

High above Hollyberry Village, one little star twinkled... and winked.

Juniper waved with her whole paw. “Goodnight, little light.”

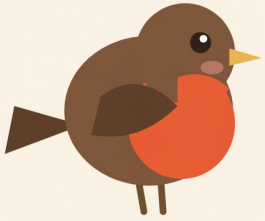
Then she snuggled into her scarf beside Grandma, curled into a cozy, prickly ball, and fell fast asleep until spring.

And all winter long, Juniper dreamed of Christmas, the very first one she ever saw.

The End

Let's Talk About the Story

- Juniper had never seen Christmas. What would you show her first?
- Why do you think Juniper gave Glimmer her brand-new scarf?
- Ruby, Ember and Oakley each helped in a different way. How do you help your friends?
- How did the whole village help Glimmer get home?
- What makes you feel warm and glowing inside?



About the Author

Clara Winterbourne writes cozy, read-aloud picture books for little ones and the grown-ups who tuck them in. She believes the best stories end with a warm feeling and a sleepy smile, and that even the smallest kindness can light up the darkest night. Juniper and the Little Lost Star is her first Christmas story.

Goodnight, little light.